Subject: Re: Talk
Date: Friday, June 12, 2026 at 11:53:24 Eastern Daylight Time
From: Murray, Dakota <dsmurray@albany.edu>
To: Levine, Charles Roger (dzk3ja) <charles.levine@virginia.edu>
Attachments: pnas.2021.118.issue-16.largecover.png

Hey Charles!

Thanks so much, I love the chance to read and digest the project. It seals the deal for me that the project is really interesting! I have a couple of comments below, these are just things I was thinking about while reading the paper, so I have no idea if they are useful or not. If I think about other things, or find other papers, I will certainly send them your way! Please do send me any updates on this you have as you progress, I'd love to keep reading and thinking about the problem.

Talent and distinguishability:
One thing I am thinking about is that elite environments themselves select on talent. Only the most talented people get into those places to begin with. What this means it that everyone in the elite environment is talented, and in fact they are likely to have roughly the *same* talent.

If talent is on a scale between 0 and 100, then a mid-tier environment might have a talent range of [60,80]. An elite environment, meanwhile, might have a compressed talent range of [98,99]. What this means is that it's basically not possible to distinguish talent at the most elite environments, because everyone is roughly equally talented.

I think this is a subtle nuance in the competitive constraints you discuss. It would imply that advancement in elite environments are essentially random, because it is impossible to tell the difference between talent.

This may be more relevant to the generative model. It may not be the case that talent can be clearly ranked in elite environments. Rather, talent in the most elite environment may be uniformly distributed (e.g., everyone is ranked the same).

"Talent" or "performance" is not all there is
Building on the last point — those in elite environments are all similarly talented. This means that evaluation is not really distinguishing on "talent" *per se*, but other important characteristics.

For example, in Academic, at the highest level, your research performance is important, but so too are things like "do you engage with the public?", "are you an asshole to be around?", "are you a very effective teacher?".

The model and approach you have now assumes that performance or talent are the metrics that *should* or *do* guide promotion. However, evaluation considers multiple factors, not all of which are possible to observe. I don't think this is a problem for your approach, but maybe something to think about.

Tenure is not a scarce resource
So basketball is interesting, because as far as I know, there are only so many “slots” available for the NBA. That is, there is a maximum number of players, unless more teams are created. In other words, there is a scarcity of advancement opportunities.

Academic tenure operates differently. Yes, there are roughly a limited number of “slots” for professors. However, tenure is more of a pass-fail system. In most cases, there is **not** a limited number of slots for tenured faculty. The faculty who are going up for tenure have, by definition, already “won” the competition for scarce professor slots, and now scarcity does not really play into the decision.

Clarifying what “career outcomes” mean
Tenure is an “up or out” promotion system — if you don’t get tenure, then you are effectively kicked out of the university. However, this is *not* the end of the line for many academics.

At elite universities like Harvard, almost no one gets tenure. However

Emergence of prestige
I like your idea about seeing how prestige emerges at large scales. It makes me think a lot of this paper by Phil Chadrow and others:

Emergence of hierarchy in networked endorsement dynamics
pnas.org

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On Jun 8, 2026, at 12:34 PM, Levine, Charles Roger (dzk3ja) <charles.levine@virginia.edu> wrote:

Dakota,

As requested, here is a concise overview of a research project that began in Army promotion systems and has since expanded into NCAA basketball and academic tenure settings. The project currently forms the foundation of the final phase of my dissertation work with Alex Gates.

Charles

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RLTW!

From: Murray, Dakota <dsmurray@albany.edu>
Date: Wednesday, June 3, 2026 at 22:30
To: Levine, Charles Roger (dzk3ja) <charles.levine@virginia.edu>
Subject: Re: Talk

Charles, thank you so much! It was also fantastic to chat with you. The project you are working on is honestly so interesting and I really look forward to reading more, so please do send something my way in the near future!

It's also just nice to chat with you, you know a lot and have such an interesting perspective. I'm an academic who studies academia — perhaps the most navel-gazing role imaginable. I love seeing how this kind of work can connect to so many different areas (and I can already see how your work will connect to mine!)

- Dakota

On Jun 3, 2026, at 3:44 PM, Levine, Charles Roger (dzk3ja) <charles.levine@virginia.edu> wrote:

Dakota,
Thanks so very much for your time today. I especially appreciated your ability to seamlessly treat me as both a mentee and collaborator. Expect to hear from me soon!

Charles

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